

Training and Experience-Driven Development

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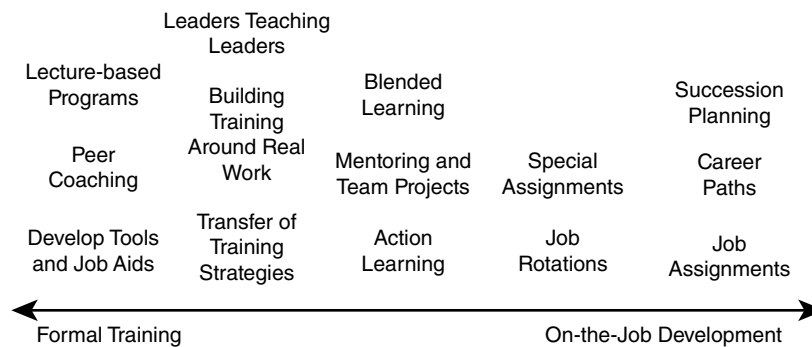
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A FRAMEWORK THAT starts with the assumption that 90 percent of a leader's development will occur outside of the classroom forces a person to think about training from a whole new perspective. In this outside-in model, the training program isn't the point, but a catalyst to drive leadership development outside the classroom. Formal training becomes an accelerator for on-the-job development. Classroom leadership development still serves a few critical functions:

- To highlight the on-the-job experiences that are most critical in a leader's development (for example, what is the short list of key leadership development experiences?).
- To practice and develop meta-skills that will promote growth in the experiences (for example, seeking feedback, reflection).
- To remember the important role that managers play in developing their direct reports and helping them to learn from experience.

Figure 57.1 illustrates a continuum we might use to think about leadership training and development in this framework. Formal classroom training represents one end of the

Figure 57.1. A Continuum of Training and On-the-Job Development

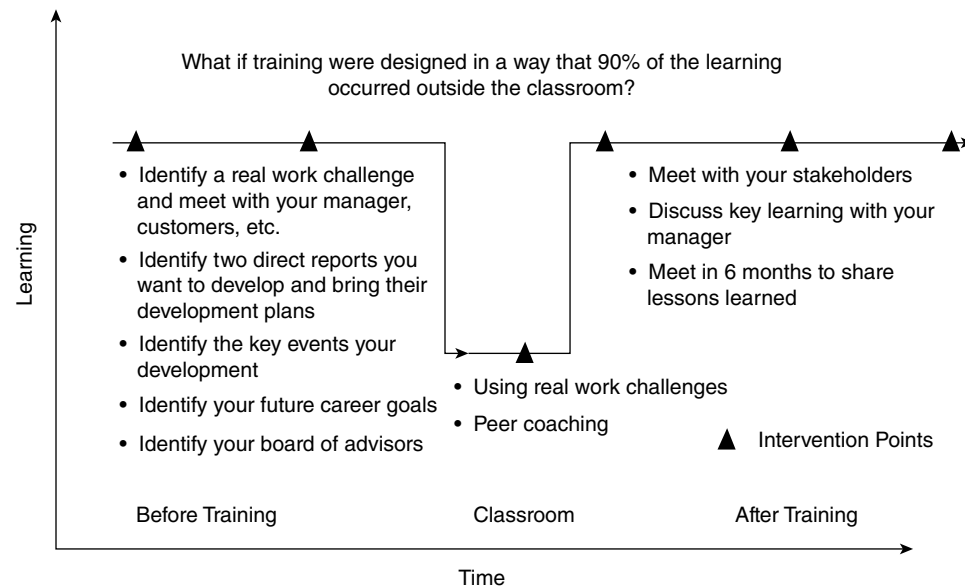
spectrum and on-the-job development represents the other, but the whole spectrum is considered from the experience side. Contrast this with the typical leadership development program that starts with the training and discusses pre-training and post-training conditions that promote transfer. Even the word “transfer” implies that the center of the action is the training program rather than the reality that the training program is one event among many significant events in a leader’s development. Starting with experience opens up new ways to turn training into a catalyst for on-the-job development.

Formal Training

Building experience-driven development into formal classroom training might start with a mini-lecture on the lessons of experience, including a reflection activity on the key experiences in the participant’s career, a review of the key experiences in the lessons of experience research, followed by identification of the key experiences that the leader would like to pursue in the future. Activities might also include building development plans for one or two direct reports. Senior leaders can share the key experiences they learned in their careers and advice for aspiring leaders in the company. The training class itself might be more of a workshop where leaders are working on real world problems and coaching each other; in essence, bringing the work into the classroom. See Elaine Beich’s contribution, *Bringing the Real World into the Classroom*, on page 375 of this book for several other great examples about integrating experience development into training. Also look at the ExperiencePoint contribution, *Building Experience into Simulations*, on page 397 of this book.

Transfer of Training

Imagine that more learning and development occurred before or after class than during it. Let’s push the idea even further, and imagine that 90 percent of the learning occurs before and after class. If true, what would need to happen before, during, and after class for that

Figure 57.2. Training That Promotes More Learning Outside the Classroom Than Happens Inside It

to occur? How can we trigger that kind of learning? Figure 57.2 illustrates several strategies that could serve as catalysts. Leaders could be encouraged before training to meet with their bosses to discuss next steps in their careers. They could meet with clients and employees before the training workshop and bring that information to use during the workshop. Participants could bring the development plans of two direct reports to practice building on-the-job development into the developmental activities. To encourage post-training work, a follow-up class could be organized six months later to discuss what happened and share lessons learned. Peer coaching groups might meet during the class and could be encouraged to continue to connect and coach each other leading up to the follow-up class.

Action Learning

Eventually, leadership development that is focused on a real business problem becomes so applied that it looks like action learning. The balance between development and work tips toward the work side and the projects become the focus with development happening along the way. Projects are short-term with a limited scope, but the stakes can be high since action learning projects are often sponsored by senior leaders in the organization. (See *Business-Driven Action Learning* on page 413 of this book.)

Mentoring and Communities of Practice

People play a critical role in a leader's development. Mentoring programs offer a structured way to promote learning from other people. (See *Mentoring: Building Leaders in Powerful*

Developmental Relationships on page 405 of this book.) Likewise, communities of practice can be organized to encourage the sharing of best practices and lessons learned, with opportunities for peer coaching within and between organizations (See *Better Together: Building Learning Communities Across Organizations* on page 433 of this book.) In these cases, classroom experience is not even needed. Learning comes through others. Development can be embedded in the work with a mentor providing advice and guidance in the context of daily tasks and challenges.

Special Assignments and Job Rotations

Take action learning to its logical conclusion and it will evolve into putting a promising leader into a special assignment that will stretch him or her in an undeveloped area. Take a lot of short-term temporary assignments, put them in a pre-planned sequence, and the result looks a lot like a formal job rotation program. The classroom, if it is used at all, becomes a catalyst to prepare participants before they enter the job rotation program or as a chance to meet with fellow job rotation candidates during the process to share what is happening, provide mutual support, and share lessons learned. At this stage, the majority of planned development truly does happen on the job.

Job Assignments

At the extreme, we find ourselves thinking about longer-term job assignments; the focus of *Lessons of Experience*. Leaders are developed when they are in trial-by-fire, edge-of-your-comfort-zone experiences where learning isn't just an option, but required to survive. Leaders start feeling like classroom training is getting in the way if it doesn't help them meet the challenges that they are facing right now and developing the skills to meet those challenges. Sound familiar? Under the old training model, these trainee complaints are likely to be seen as a leader who isn't very open to learning (aka, learning what the trainer thinks is important). *Hotspots: Blended Learning to Empower NGOs* on page 389 of this book highlights how a learning management system can be built to directly support the needs of the participants as they are trying to solve real world challenges.

As you read these contributions, I challenge you to think about the chapters from the perspective of a business leader who is challenged to grow and develop in his or her job every day. Ask yourself: How can the programs be rolled out so they support and accelerate that learning? How can the programs be designed so they are catalysts for greater learning on the job?